



Lab in the Wild

Email Writing Study

🕒 Approximately 20–30 minutes

Thank you for participating in this study. We are researchers interested in how people write professional emails in everyday workplace situations.

Your responses are completely voluntary and will be kept confidential. You may withdraw at any time without penalty.



Task 1

Write an email on your own



Task 2

Write an email with AI assistance



Task 3

Write an email with AI assistance

Start now!

Before we get started, here are a few things you should know...



What is this study all about?

In this study, you will be asked to write professional emails in a series of workplace scenarios. We are interested in how people communicate in professional settings.

This will take around 20–30 minutes.

What data are we going to collect?

We will collect the emails you write during the study, along with basic demographic information. We will not collect your name or contact information. Your data will be stored securely and used only for research purposes.

Do I have to be in this study?

No, participation is entirely voluntary. You can stop at any time without penalty.



Who can you contact if you have questions?

If you have questions, please contact the research team at study@iu.edu.

If you want to talk about the study with someone who is not part of the study team, contact the Indiana University IRB at irb@iu.edu.

☐ I agree to participate in this research.

You must check the box to continue.



About your supervisor in this study

In each task, we would like you to imagine the following situation: **you have recently started a new job and have met your supervisor only once. You do not yet know them well.**

Also, in each scenario, **your supervisor is currently away from the office and has asked to be contacted by email only for the next day or two.**

Personalized feedback:

At the end of the study, you will receive personalized feedback based on the emails you write. You will learn whether your communication style tends toward more direct or more contextual communication. **To make this feedback meaningful, please write each email as naturally as you would in that situation.**





A few things to keep in mind

- ✓ There are no right or wrong answers. We are interested in how you would naturally write.
- ✓ Please write the email as if you were actually going to send it.
- ✓ Take your time — write the email the way you genuinely would in that situation.
- ✓ Do not worry about grammar or spelling — content matters more.



TASK 1

Task 1: Write an email on your own

Situation:

You have a report due this Friday. Yesterday you discovered a major error in the data analysis that requires you to redo a significant portion of the work. You estimate you need two extra days. The report is scheduled to be delivered to a client on Friday, and the client is relying on it to prepare for an important presentation on Monday. If you need an extension, your boss will have to contact the client directly to explain the delay. Without the extension, the report will be incomplete and potentially inaccurate.

To boss@company.com

Subject Enter a subject line...

Write your email here...

Make sure you edit the email in ways that you feel comfortable sending to your boss.

▶ Send



Using the AI writing assistant

For the next two tasks, you will write about the same situation again — this time with the help of an AI writing assistant.

- ✓ You can ask the AI to draft the email for you.
- ✓ You are free to edit the draft generated by the AI in any way you like.
- ✓ The final email you submit is what matters — write it in whatever way feels right to you.



TASK 2

Task 2: Write an email with AI assistance

Situation:

You have a report due this Friday. Yesterday you discovered a major error in the data analysis that requires you to redo a significant portion of the work. You estimate you need two extra days. The report is scheduled to be delivered to a client on Friday, and the client is relying on it to prepare for an important presentation on Monday. If you need an extension, your boss will have to contact the client directly to explain the delay. Without the extension, the report will be incomplete and potentially inaccurate.

You can use the AI assistant to help you write a first draft.

[Generate Draft](#)

To boss@company.com

Subject Enter a subject line...

Write your email here, or click Generate Draft above...

Make sure you edit the email in ways that you feel comfortable sending to your boss.

[▶ Send](#)

TASK 3

Task 3: Write an email with AI assistance

Situation:

You have a report due this Friday. Yesterday you discovered a major error in the data analysis that requires you to redo a significant portion of the work. You estimate you need two extra days. The report is scheduled to be delivered to a client on Friday, and the client is relying on it to prepare for an important presentation on Monday. If you need an extension, your boss will have to contact the client directly to explain the delay. Without the extension, the report will be incomplete and potentially inaccurate.

You can use the AI assistant to help you write a first draft.

[Generate Draft](#)

To boss@company.com

Subject Enter a subject line...

Write your email here, or click Generate Draft above...

Make sure you edit the email in ways that you feel comfortable sending to your boss.

[▶ Send](#)



Which AI draft felt more natural?

Looking back at the two AI-generated drafts you received — one in Task 2 and one in Task 3 — which felt more natural or appropriate for the situation?

- ☐ The draft from Task 2
- ☐ The draft from Task 3
- ☐ Both felt equally natural
- ☐ Neither felt natural





Tell us a little about yourself

All fields marked with * are required.

How old are you? *

What is your gender? *

What is your highest level of formal education? *

How long have you been working at your current company? *

How often do you use AI tools in general (e.g., ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot)? *



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Thank you for your participation!

Before you see your results, please let us know what you thought of the study.

Do you have any comments for the researcher? (Questions, suggestions, or concerns?)

Did you encounter any technical difficulties during this study?

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Is there any reason why researchers should exclude your data? (For example, if you were interrupted or did not respond seriously.)

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You're all done!

Thank you for participating in this study. Your responses have been recorded.

Your personalized communication style feedback will be sent to you by email within a few days.

What happens next?

Our research team will analyze the emails you wrote and determine whether your communication style tends toward direct (low-context) or contextual (high-context) communication. You will receive a short personalized report based on your writing.

This feedback is for educational purposes only and does not reflect a judgment of your communication skills.

If you have any questions about this study, please contact the research team at study@iu.edu.

If you enjoyed this study, there's more!

litw-more-step1

 facebook.com/LabintheWild/

litw-more-step2

